

Chapter 158-3

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When Xu Qingzhu returned to the company, she happened to run into Lin Luoxi and the others coming down to eat.

"Come on." Lin Luoxi pulled her outside without another word. "Let's go eat."

Xu Qingzhu wanted to refuse, but Lin Luoxi pinched her face. "Look at you—you've gotten so thin these past few days. If you don't eat, I'm going to call Liang Shi."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

The threat worked. Xu Qingzhu smiled helplessly: "I'm really not hungry."

"How can a person not be hungry?" Lin Luoxi said. "You didn't eat breakfast this morning either. If you keep losing weight, you'll turn into a skeleton."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Can you not be so dramatic?" Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "It's not that scary."

"If you don't believe me, ask Sally." Lin Luoxi said. "Have you weighed yourself these past few days? You've lost at least five jin¹. Are you planning to enter the entertainment industry?"

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"Why would I enter the entertainment industry for no reason?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I'm already too busy with the company every day."

"Only female celebrities in the entertainment industry are competing over their figures like that."² Lin Luoxi pinched her face again, but this time she couldn't grab any flesh at all. Instead, she just pinched the skin on Xu Qingzhu's face red, making Xu Qingzhu gasp from the pain.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her: "I suspect you're taking personal revenge."

Lin Luoxi reached out to rub it for her: "What personal grudge could there be between us? Baby, I don't even have enough time to dote on you."

Her tone was intimate yet carried a hint of sarcasm, making Xu Qingzhu shiver. She immediately rubbed her arms and said: "Don't do that..."

Sally, standing to the side, looked aggrieved: "Baby, why are you calling someone else 'baby'?"

Lin Luoxi: "...You're so annoying."

Sally: "?"

"OMG." Sally looked like she'd seen a ghost. "Baby, I'm your girlfriend."

Lin Luoxi's face was cold: "So?"

Sally: "...?"

"You're not allowed to call anyone else 'baby.'" Sally said.

Xu Qingzhu, standing to the side, silently moved further away to avoid being caught up in the couple's war.

"So what if I called her that?" Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes and scoffed. "Why are you so possessive? I was calling Zhuzi, you know. Besides, even if I called a stranger that, it wouldn't be a big deal, right? You're so petty."

Sally was so angry she was speechless. Mainly because her Chinese wasn't good enough to argue back.

So she took out her phone: "I'm going to call Liang Shi and ask if she can accept it!"

Lin Luoxi: "...Are you crazy?"

Sally: "Do you have medicine?"

Lin Luoxi: "..."

Lin Luoxi pulled Xu Qingzhu forward, looking like she didn't want anyone to know she was acquainted with this idiot.

But Xu Qingzhu turned back and called out to Sally: "Don't call her."

But it was too late—Sally had already gotten through.

So Liang Shi happened to hear that sentence, and she had the illusion that she hadn't heard Xu Qingzhu's voice in a very long time.

When clearly they had only been apart for a few days.

Sally jogged to catch up with Lin Luoxi and the others, putting the phone on speaker as she went. She asked Liang Shi very righteously: "Can you accept Blanche calling someone else 'baby'?"

Liang Shi was awkward: "Uh..."

Caught off guard by this question, Liang Shi was stunned for a moment, but then asked: "Is Xu Qingzhu next to you?"

"Of course." Sally and Lin Luoxi had already taken their seats. Xu Qingzhu was holding the menu the server had handed her, pinching one corner of it. She appeared to be looking down and thinking about what to order, but she was actually listening intently to what was happening on the other end.

Sally complained: "My baby always calls other people 'baby.' She really is... too much."

Lin Luoxi held her forehead: "Just hang up already."

Sally: "No."

Lin Luoxi glared at her: "Do you want to die?"

Sally: "No."

They simply couldn't communicate.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu curled up in the corner, marked the dishes she wanted to order, then handed the menu back to the server. She sat there with her hands in her pockets, basking in the sun, with no desire to interject at all.

"Liang Shi, be the judge." Sally asked. "Can you accept it?"

Liang Shi: "...Uh."

"Don't be embarrassed." Sally said. "I can't accept it! I only want my baby to call me that."

Lin Luoxi's ears grew hot. She kicked Sally under the table. "That's enough!"

Sally grabbed her hand from across the table. "I'm just telling the truth."

Lin Luoxi pulled her hand away, saying through gritted teeth: "Have some shame."

Sally: "..."

Sally continued to press Liang Shi, clearly determined not to give up until she got an answer.

After a moment, Liang Shi answered carefully: "It's okay, I guess."

Sally was surprised: "What?"

It was only okay?!

Sally was immediately thrown into chaos. Was she the only one with such strong possessiveness?!

This didn't make sense.

"Because she wouldn't call anyone else 'baby.'" Liang Shi said over the phone. "So I don't feel anything about it."

Sally: "?"

Reasonably suspecting you're just showing off.

Sally was choked with anger. "Fine, then let's leave it at that. I'm hanging up."

1. Jin (斤) is a Chinese unit of weight. One jin equals 500 grams or approximately 1.1 pounds. Five jin would be about 2.5 kilograms or 5.5 pounds. ⇐
2. The original Chinese term "内卷" (nèi juǎn, literally "involution") refers to excessive competition where people work harder and harder just to maintain their position or get ahead, often with diminishing returns. In this context, it refers to female celebrities in China's entertainment industry competing intensely over having the thinnest figures. ⇐